IR Exam Case Bank — 15 "why" questions × 5 theories

> **How to use.** For any question, pick ONE theory as your main answer and ONE as your rebutted counter. Each row = that theory's angle, the concepts to name, two empirical examples, and the weakness to expect in the counterargument. ⚠️ = forced fit (that theory struggles here; good to know for picking a *counter*, risky as a *main*).
>
> **5 theories:** Realism (structural) · Liberal institutionalism · Liberal internationalism · Constructivism · Critical theory. Examples are *named only* — flesh out the identity/mechanism story yourself in the essay.

1. Why do rival states cooperate in one area while staying hostile in another?

Theory	Explanation (1-line)	Key concepts	2 examples	Weakness
Realism	Cooperate where it doesn't shift the relative balance; hostile where it does	relative vs absolute gains, balance of power, self-help	Russia–EU gas (vs NATO); India–China trade (vs border)	Struggles to explain *durable, institutionalised* cooperation
Lib. institutionalism	Issue-specific regimes make cooperation safe in one domain	regimes, reciprocity, issue-areas	US–USSR arms control (Cold War); US–China climate talks amid trade war	Can't explain persisting hostility
Lib. internationalism ⚠️	Domestic coalitions favour cooperation on some issues, not others	preferences, domestic interests	US–China (business lobby vs security hawks)	Thin on *why rivalry persists*; forced
Constructivism	Different shared meanings/identities built per issue-area	identity, norms, intersubjective meaning	US–China (economic partner vs strategic rival framing)	Weak at predicting *which* area turns cooperative
Critical theory	Cooperation serves dominant economic interests; hostility masks it	hegemony, class/capital, core–periphery	Russia–EU energy capital flows; Gulf states–West	Hard to test; over-reads everything as capital

2. Why do some states abandon a military capability they've already developed?

Theory	Explanation	Key concepts	2 examples	Weakness
Realism	Abandon when a guarantee/alliance covers the need, or coerced	security guarantee, extended deterrence, relative power	Kazakhstan/Ukraine (assurances); Germany/Japan post-45	Distrusts institutions — awkward with voluntary treaty disarmament
Lib. institutionalism	Institutions make verified mutual disarmament safe	reciprocity, monitoring, NPT/regimes	Brazil–Argentina (ABACC); Kazakhstan (NPT)	Can't explain defection (North Korea leaving NPT)
Lib. internationalism	New domestic coalition (democratisation) drops the programme	regime change, preferences	Brazil & Argentina (post-dictatorship); South Africa	Needs a domestic shift — silent when there isn't one
Constructivism	A norm (non-proliferation taboo) reshapes identity	norms, taboo, socialisation	nuclear taboo; South Africa's post-apartheid identity	Weak where disarmament is clearly coerced
Critical theory	The strong pressure the weak to disarm while keeping their own	hierarchy, two-tier order, hegemony	NPT haves/have-nots; Libya/Iraq WMD disarmament	Can't explain equal-power mutual disarmament (Brazil–Argentina)

3. Why are great powers more likely than small states to break rules they helped create?

Theory	Explanation	Key concepts	2 examples	Weakness
Realism	They can — relative power lets them ignore rules; small states can't	relative power, self-help, hegemony	US–Iraq 2003; Russia–Crimea/Ukraine	Can't explain why great powers *ever* obey
Lib. institutionalism	Great powers depend on institutions less, so costs of breaking bite less	dependence, reputation, reciprocity	US tariffs/WTO; US & ICC	Under-predicts how often great powers *do* comply
Lib. internationalism ⚠️	Domestic politics (nationalism, executives) push rule-breaking	domestic coalitions, executive power	Trump "America First"; Brexit	Doesn't track the *great/small* split cleanly; forced
Constructivism	Great powers' identity = exceptional/above the rules they authored	identity, exceptionalism, logic of appropriateness	US exceptionalism (Iraq, ICC); Russia's "great power" self-image	Must show identity, not just the act (reads as realism)
Critical theory	The order is built to serve the powerful; "rules" bind only the weak	hegemony, who-writes-the-rules	UNSC veto; US & ICC exemption	Hard to falsify

4. Why do democracies rarely fight each other?

Theory	Explanation	Key concepts	2 examples	Weakness
Realism ⚠️	Not democracy — shared interests, alliances, Cold War structure	balance of power, alliances, polarity	NATO democracies vs USSR; US–UK alliance	Denies a robust empirical finding; defensive
Lib. institutionalism	Dense institutions + interdependence make war too costly	interdependence, IOs, absolute gains	EU members; Bretton Woods order	Doesn't explain the *democracy-specific* pattern
Lib. internationalism	Accountability, public opinion, transparency restrain war	Kantian triangle, democratic peace, accountability	no two mature democracies fought (20th c.); EU	"Democracy" is contested; edge-case wars exist
Constructivism	Democracies share an in-group identity — war feels inappropriate	identity, shared norms, "we-feeling"	transatlantic community; EU "security community"	Hard to measure "identity"; risks circularity
Critical theory ⚠️	"Democratic peace" masks shared capitalist-class interest	capital, hegemony, ideology	Western bloc cohesion; global capital order	Strains against the clean empirical record

5. Why do states comply with international law no one can enforce?

Theory	Explanation	Key concepts	2 examples	Weakness
Realism	Only when it serves interests / the powerful want it	self-help, power, hegemony	UNCLOS when convenient; great-power selectivity	Can't explain costly compliance
Lib. institutionalism	Reputation + reciprocity + shadow of the future make it pay	reciprocity, reputation, regimes	WTO rulings mostly obeyed; trade law	Weak vs great-power defection
Lib. internationalism	Domestic courts/groups internalise and demand compliance	domestic institutions, preferences	ECHR in domestic courts; EU law	Varies hugely by regime type
Constructivism	Law is internalised as "appropriate"; identity as law-abiding	norms, logic of appropriateness, legitimacy	decolonisation norm; torture taboo	Can't explain brazen violations
Critical theory	Law legitimises the powerful; compliance = consent to hegemony	hegemony, legitimation, ideology	investment/trade law favouring the core	Over-reads; hard to test

6. Why do arms races happen?

Theory	Explanation	Key concepts	2 examples	Weakness
Realism	Security dilemma — defensive build-ups look offensive under anarchy	security dilemma, self-help, relative gains	US–USSR Cold War; pre-1914 naval race	Can't explain restraint/de-escalation
Lib. institutionalism	Failure of institutions to provide information/reassurance	information, monitoring, regimes	arms-control treaties that *stopped* races (INF)	Explains the *fix* better than the *race*
Lib. internationalism	Domestic lobbies (military-industrial complex) drive it	interest groups, domestic preferences	US defence lobby; Cold War procurement	Needs a specific domestic driver
Constructivism ⚠️	Rival identities make the other's arms seem threatening	identity, enmity, social facts	India–Pakistan rivalry; US–USSR enmity	Thin on *why build-ups spiral*
Critical theory	Arms racing serves capital/the military-industrial order	capital, militarism, class	arms industry profits; Cold War economy	Hard to falsify

7. Why do states form alliances?

Theory	Explanation	Key concepts	2 examples	Weakness
Realism	Balance against a greater threat (or bandwagon with it)	balance of power, threat, bandwagoning	NATO vs USSR; anti-Napoleon coalitions	Struggles with alliance *persistence* after threat ends (NATO post-91)
Lib. institutionalism	Alliances as institutions lowering cooperation costs	institutions, reciprocity, credible commitment	NATO's enduring structure; EU defence	Under-weights raw threat
Lib. internationalism	Shared regime type/domestic affinity	democratic peace, preferences	NATO democracies; US–UK	Doesn't explain alliances *with* autocracies
Constructivism	Shared identity/community, not just threat	identity, security community	transatlantic community; ASEAN	Weak when alliances are purely instrumental
Critical theory	Alliances entrench the hegemon's order	hegemony, core, dependency	US alliance system; client states	Over-reads; hard to test

8. Why do international institutions persist even when they can't compel states?

Theory	Explanation	Key concepts	2 examples	Weakness
Realism	They persist only while they serve the powerful	power, hegemony, instrument	UNSC veto; IMF weighted votes	Can't explain institutions outliving their founder's interest
Lib. institutionalism	They lower transaction costs, solve collective-action problems	regimes, reciprocity, info, shadow of future	WTO; WHO; UN system	Over-optimistic vs great-power sidelining
Lib. internationalism	Domestic groups benefit and lobby to keep them	domestic preferences, embeddedness	EU constituencies; trade lobbies	Varies by state
Constructivism	They become taken-for-granted, part of "normal" order	norms, legitimacy, institutionalisation	the UN's legitimacy; sovereignty norm	Can't explain sudden collapses
Critical theory	They reproduce the hegemonic order and look "natural"	hegemony, legitimation, Gramsci	IMF/World Bank conditionality; Bretton Woods	Hard to falsify

9. Why do states (sometimes) intervene in humanitarian crises?

Theory	Explanation	Key concepts	2 examples	Weakness
Realism	Only when strategic interests coincide; otherwise they don't	national interest, power	Libya 2011 (interest-aligned); Rwanda 1994 (non-intervention)	Can't explain genuinely costly intervention
Lib. institutionalism	Collective action via IOs/authorisation	collective security, IOs, R2P	UN-authorised missions; R2P	Weak when IOs are paralysed
Lib. internationalism	Public opinion/domestic pressure drives it	public opinion, accountability	"CNN effect"; democratic publics	Inconsistent across cases
Constructivism	Widening norms of who "deserves" protection	norms, identity, logic of appropriateness	Somalia 1992; R2P norm emergence	Can't explain non-intervention (Rwanda)
Critical theory	"Humanitarian" cover for hegemonic/economic interests	hegemony, imperialism critique	Iraq/Libya resource angle	Cynical; hard to test

10. Why do some rivalries end in war while others stay peaceful?

Theory	Explanation	Key concepts	2 examples	Weakness
Realism	Power shifts / security dilemma tip rivalry into war	power transition, security dilemma	WWI (rising Germany); US–USSR *avoided* war (MAD)	Indeterminate — predicts both
Lib. institutionalism	Institutions + interdependence raise war's cost	interdependence, regimes	EU ending Franco-German war; 1914 (failed)	Interdependence didn't stop 1914
Lib. internationalism	Regime type — democracies avoid war with each other	democratic peace, accountability	Western Europe post-45; India–Pakistan (not democracies-pair)	Edge cases
Constructivism	Whether the rival is constructed as enemy or competitor	enmity, identity, "anarchy is what states make of it"	US–Canada (amity) vs US–USSR (enmity)	Hard to predict ex ante
Critical theory ⚠️	War/peace reflects material/class structures	capital, imperialism	WWI imperial rivalry	Coarse; hard to test

11. Why do states pursue nuclear weapons?

Theory	Explanation	Key concepts	2 examples	Weakness
Realism	Security under anarchy; deterrence vs a threat	self-help, deterrence, security dilemma	North Korea; Pakistan (vs India)	Can't explain restraint by capable states (Japan)
Lib. institutionalism	Regimes (NPT) raise costs → most *don't*	NPT, regimes, reciprocity	NPT near-universal membership	Explains non-pursuit better than pursuit
Lib. internationalism	Domestic politics/prestige coalitions	domestic interests, prestige	India's domestic drivers	Needs case-specific coalition
Constructivism	Prestige/identity (a "great power has the bomb") or taboo restrains	identity, prestige, nuclear taboo	France's force de frappe; non-nuclear norm	Competing identity claims cut both ways
Critical theory ⚠️	The order lets the core keep bombs, denies the periphery	hierarchy, two-tier NPT	NPT haves vs have-nots	Doesn't explain *why* a given state builds

12. Why has great-power war declined since 1945?

Theory	Explanation	Key concepts	2 examples	Weakness
Realism	Nuclear deterrence (MAD) + bipolar stability	deterrence, polarity, balance of power	US–USSR Cold War peace; MAD	Can't explain peace among non-nuclear democracies
Lib. institutionalism	Dense institutions + interdependence raise costs	interdependence, IOs, regimes	EU; Bretton Woods/WTO order	Didn't stop proxy wars
Lib. internationalism	Spread of democracy → democratic peace	democratic peace, Kantian triangle	post-45 Western Europe	Doesn't cover autocracies' restraint
Constructivism	A norm against great-power war took hold	norms, taboo, learning	WWI/WWII "never again"; war delegitimised	Hard to isolate the norm's effect
Critical theory	US hegemony imposed a stable (profitable) order	hegemony, Pax Americana	Bretton Woods; dollar order	Over-credits structure

13. Why do states sometimes act against their material interests?

Theory	Explanation	Key concepts	2 examples	Weakness
Realism ⚠️	They don't, really — apparent losses serve power/security	national interest, relative gains	costly signalling; alliance commitments	Explains the behaviour away rather than *for* it
Lib. institutionalism	Short-term cost for long-term reciprocal gain	shadow of the future, reciprocity	sunk reputational costs; treaty compliance	Stretches "interest" to fit
Lib. internationalism	A domestic coalition's interest ≠ the "national" one	domestic preferences, lobbies	tariffs hurting consumers; farm subsidies	Needs the coalition identified
Constructivism	Identity/norms override material calculation	identity, logic of appropriateness, norms	Germany's restraint; costly norm compliance	Hard to prove norms *caused* it
Critical theory	"National interest" masks a *class* interest being served	class, ideology, hegemony	austerity serving capital	Hard to falsify

14. Why do economic sanctions often fail?

Theory	Explanation	Key concepts	2 examples	Weakness
Realism	Targets prioritise survival over economic pain; rivals help them	self-help, survival, balancing	Russia post-2014/2022; North Korea	Under-weights when sanctions *do* work
Lib. institutionalism	Work only with multilateral coordination/monitoring	collective action, regimes, monitoring	UN vs unilateral sanctions; leaky regimes	Hard to sustain coordination
Lib. internationalism	Target's domestic regime insulates elites from pain	regime type, domestic structure	authoritarian resilience (Iran, NK)	Varies by regime
Constructivism	Sanctions can harden a besieged national identity	identity, rally-round-the-flag	Iran; Russia's "fortress" narrative	Hard to measure
Critical theory	Sanctions reinforce core dominance; hurt the periphery's poor	hierarchy, dependency	sanctions' humanitarian toll	Doesn't explain *failure* vs success

15. Why do power transitions (rising powers) cause conflict?

Theory	Explanation	Key concepts	2 examples	Weakness
Realism	Rising power unsettles the balance → security dilemma, war risk	power transition, balance of power, Thucydides trap	US–China today; rising Germany pre-1914	Many transitions *don't* end in war
Lib. institutionalism	Institutions can socialise a riser peacefully	regimes, integration, interdependence	China into WTO; post-45 order	Riser may defect once strong
Lib. internationalism	Depends on the riser's regime type/domestic politics	regime type, preferences	democratic vs autocratic risers	Hard to generalise
Constructivism	Conflict if the riser is constructed as a threatening "other"	identity, enmity, status	US–China threat framing; UK–US peaceful transition	Why peaceful sometimes? identity under-determines
Critical theory	Transition = struggle over who controls the capitalist order	hegemony, world-systems	British→American hegemony; US–China	Coarse; hard to test

Quick picking guide

- **Security / war / weapons** (6, 10, 11, 12, 15) → **realism** strongest main, **constructivism** or **liberalism** as counter.
- **Cooperation / law / institutions** (1, 2, 5, 8) → **liberalism** main, **realism** or **critical** counter.
- **Identity / norms / "why against interest"** (4, 13) → **constructivism** main, **realism** counter.
- **Who-benefits / hierarchy** (3, 9) → **critical theory** makes a sharp counter; realism/constructivism as main.
- ⚠️ rows = the theory to attack in your rebuttal, not to defend as your main.